

MOUNTAINS OF ORAKZAI

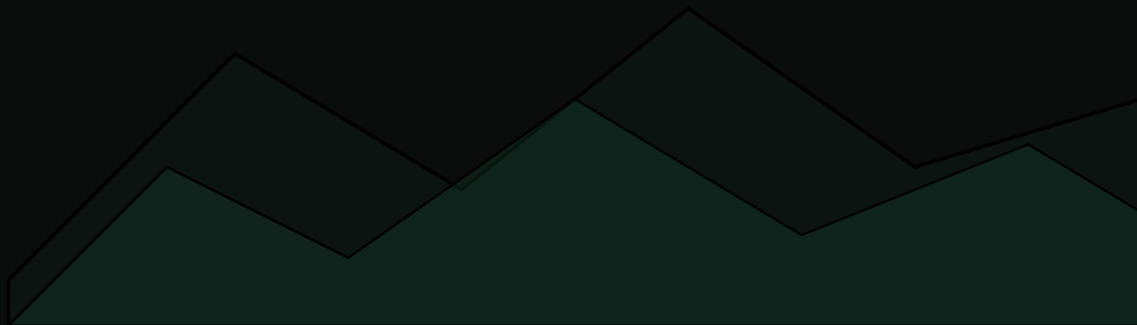
“Ridges, peaks, valleys and the landscape of a mountain homeland.”

Before there were roads, administrative boundaries and digital maps, the mountains were already there. They formed the physical landscape through which generations of Orakzai communities travelled, settled, farmed and maintained connections with neighboring regions. The mountains did not create Orakzai identity by themselves. But they became part of the geography through which that identity was lived.

Geographically, Orakzai is characterized by a rugged, mountainous tract where elevation varies substantially from west to east. Government geographic records and historical surveys describe a terrain dominated by high ridges, dissected river courses, and sheltered valleys that have shaped human movement and settlement for centuries.¹²

MOUNTAINS OF ORAKZAI

RIDGES, PEAKS, VALLEYS AND MOVEMENT



“Layered contour and vector composition representing the mountainous topography of the Orakzai homeland.”

MOUNTAIN LANDSCAPE & ELEVATION

The elevation of the hills in Orakzai varies from over 10,000 feet (approx. 3,000 m) in the rugged western reaches to less than 6,650 feet (approx. 2,030 m) in the east, with lower peripheral areas and valley bases settling around 5,200 to 5,500 feet. This westward rise in elevation creates a distinct climatic and ecological gradient across the territory.²³



“West-to-east elevation gradient across the Orakzai territory.”

TERMINOLOGY: RANGE, RIDGE, PEAK & VALLEY

Historical and administrative records often employ varying geographic terminology—using range, ridge, peak, and valley interchangeably or in specialized contexts. Understanding these features requires respecting how historical observers mapped the land while recognizing the underlying geological continuity.¹⁴



“Geographic terminology hierarchy from macro ranges to valley corridors.”

VERIFIED PEAKS: SANGLA & CHARA KANDAO

Among the documented peaks within the region are **Sangla**, standing at 1,928 meters (approx. 6,325 feet), and **Chara Kandao** (variant spelling: *Chara Kandaco*), standing at 1,720 meters (approx. 5,643 feet). These elevations and features provide verified geographic reference points in official surveys and regional compendiums.²³

PEAK NAME	VARIANT SPELLING	ELEVATION	LOCATION / CONTEXT	PRIMARY SOURCE
Sangla	—	1,928 m (6,325 ft)	Orakzai geographic sector	Pakistan Almanac & Survey Records [2] [3]
Chara Kandao	Chara Kandaco	1,720 m (5,643 ft)	Orakzai terrain sector	Pakistan Almanac & Geographic Data [2] [3]

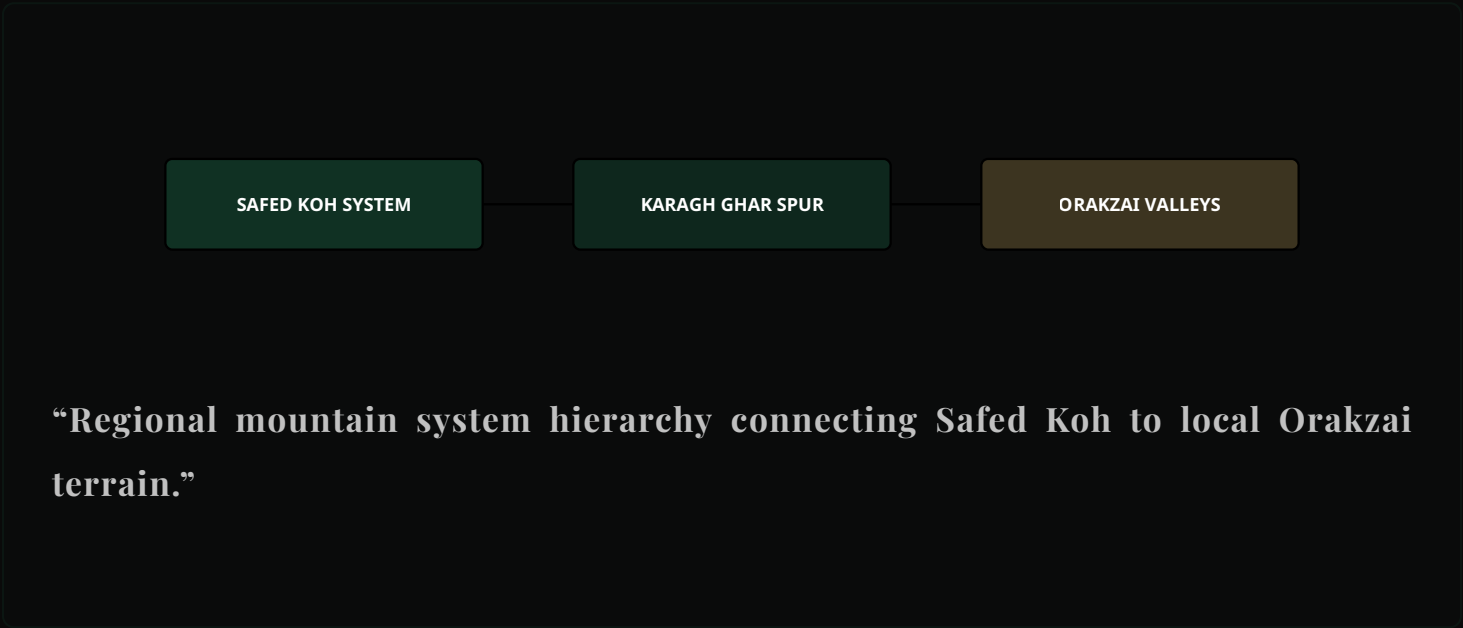


“Comparison of verified peak elevations within the regional landscape.”

MAJOR MOUNTAIN RANGES: KARAGH GHAR, SAMANA & SAFED KOH

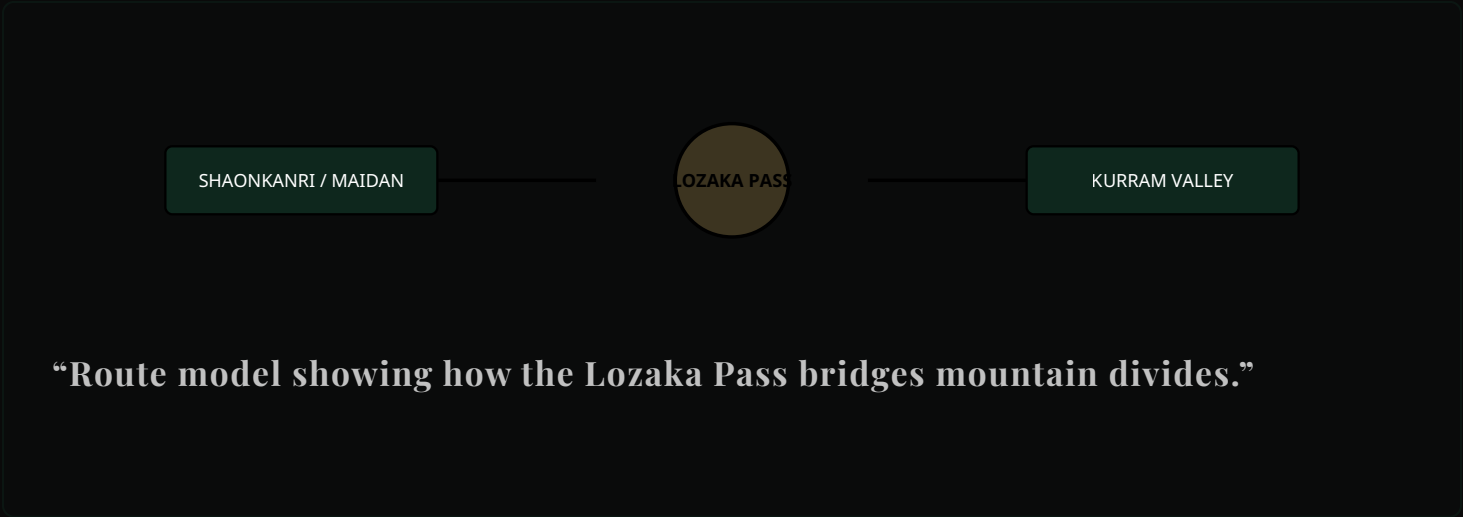
The regional mountain structure is anchored by several prominent systems. The **Karagh Ghar** (or *Kahu Ghar*) Range, a significant southern spur of the greater **Safed Koh** (Spin

Ghar) system, dominates the local hills and is dissected by numerous watercourses. To the south, the **Samana Range**—rising between 6,000 and 7,000 feet—forms a towering ridge that commands the southern boundary of the Tirah region and separates Orakzai from Hangu and the Miranzai valley.¹⁵



PASSES AND HISTORICAL ROUTES: THE LOZAKA PASS

Mountains did not merely divide communities; they were traversed by historical passes and routes that facilitated trade, travel and communication. The **Lozaka Pass** (crossing the Karagh Ghar range between Shaonkanri and Maidan) is one such historically documented route, connecting Orakzai settlements directly with the Kurram valley and broader regional networks.¹⁴



AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

When I reflect on the mountains of Orakzai, I see more than stone and elevation. I see the ancient barriers that sheltered our ancestors and the high passes that connected us to the wider world. The Samana Range and the Karagh Ghar are enduring monuments of our landscape. They remind us that while our people have migrated, adapted and entered a new era, the bones of our homeland remain anchored in these timeless heights.

“The peaks may touch the sky, but the mountains are the solid foundation upon which our identity stands.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS